

Taking India to the skies

In 1938, JRD Tata was appointed Chairman of the Tata Group, which then consisted of fourteen companies in a variety of industries. His tenure, the longest of any chairman, would see the conglomerate grow enormously in size, and diversify into new areas such as chemicals, tea production and, most importantly, aviation. Tata had been interested in flying from a very young age, and was among the first Indians to earn a commercial pilot's license. In 1932, he started an airmail service, which became the foundation of India's first ever domestic airline, Tata Airlines. Renamed Air India in 1946, the airline was nationalized in 1953, and continues to be India's national carrier today. In 2021, the Indian government sold Air India back to the Tata Group.



JRD Tata helped establish the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research (which was instrumental in helping India's atomic energy programme get off the ground), the Tata Memorial Hospital (one of India's premier cancer research and treatment centres), the Tata